

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 41

SOUTH CAROLINA
WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside South Carolina's family courts and child-welfare system.

123

SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 217 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 19 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
OCTOBER 25, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
31 OF 46

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · SOUTH CAROLINA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in South Carolina. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Ashby Jones CONTINUED 1 / 2

ATTORNEY · LEXINGTON · **10 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"After April Sampson advised she could no longer handle my case, representation was transferred to Ashby Jones. Before and during representation, my husband and I disclosed the full background of the case, including his prior history, DSS-related matters, and the concerns we believed would arise in litigation. Despite this, we were later told that counsel had not been provided the "full report" or complete information regarding my husband's history, which I dispute. The primary goals we retained counsel to pursue remained: * removal or challenge of the Temporary Restraining Order, and * addressing concerns involving the Guardian ad Litem. Despite substantial legal fees, little substantive progress was made toward those objectives. Much of the work appeared focused on reviewing emails and communications, after which additional retainers were requested. I also experienced concerns regarding: * communication, * strategy, * responsiveness, * and failure to aggressively pursue requested relief. After terminating representation, I experienced delays obtaining my complete client file, including physical documents I had personally delivered to the office and communications exchanged on my behalf. These delays impaired my ability to continue protecting my legal interests in an ongoing custody matter. Given the seriousness of the issues involved, the substantial fees incurred, and the limited progress toward the objectives for which counsel was retained, I am requesting review of the representation and billing practices in this matter."*

> *"She listened to the false information Jane Waters was telling her about me instead of listening to what I was saying, she placed blame on me so she could remove herself from my case instead of telling me she didn't want this case anymore bc of how dangerous my ex is. She left me 2 wks before mediation. She told me she would do a deposition and never did it. I spent a month working on material for her to use for the deposition."*

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Ashby Jones CONTINUED 2 / 2

ATTORNEY · LEXINGTON · **10 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Highly unethical. Labeled me as racist, right winged, "anti-vax" (even though it was only covid vaccine), etc to throw the emotions of the judge. Ashby has zero concern for the welfare of children. She is very expensive and if you have money, she can unethically flip a case for you."*

> *"Absolutely unscrupulous in false allegations in court...no police reports, no arrests, nothing to substantiate it but the court continues to allow it. Dragging on for more than 2 years."*

> *"Thinks she's God, forces her clients to follow HER strategy or she'll drop them. It is strategy over safety no matter what."*

> *"Represented my ex despite my prior consultation. Caught telling lay, court appointed GAL to "make me look bad.""*

> *"She doesn't care about the mistakes she makes or her associates makes. She is big bully."*

> *"Please see all the above for context."* RICHLAND COUNTY

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-ashby-jones/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Michelle S. Gorski

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · LEXINGTON, SC · **5 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Husband represented father in his divorce. On recording OC told her to stay in her lane and make me look worse. Didn't protect my child. Hired as 3rd gal and her husband represented father in previous divorce. Recorded her telling me Brian Dumas said to stay in her lane and make me look worse."*

> *"Submitted false information in reports, misquoted others in order to mislead the court, agreed to "make me look bad" I found out from an attorney and billed for obtained medical records, but the doctor's office confirmed they didn't charge her?"*

> *"Primary concern is money not the children she represents or the lifelong devastating effects her report will have on them."* RICHLAND

> *"Threatened the children"* RICHLAND

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-michelle-s-gorski/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Stephanie Fajardo

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · RICHLAND · **5 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"She ignored that a child abused was best friends with my ex. Nathan Ginter is best friend with my ex and he is serving 40 yrs in prison for child abuse, my ex talked to him daily in prison before he bonded out. She ignored all of my concerns of safety for my son. My ex is a drug addict with no childcare plan and no legitimate place of employment. No one knows where his income comes from our where he gets money to pay bills. She called out parental alienation and did nothing about it. My lawyer and her agreed it was severe. She sent my son to a biase counselor and caused more harm to my son. The psychological abuse is severe and on going."*

> *"She was biased towards father and spent little time with or listen to kids. Also pursued contempt charges towards me regardless of my ongoing $30 monthly payments- she expected 300 min monthly. And then essentially told me I shouldn't expect her to do her job- it was father who wanted her and I said I could not afford but had no choice."* LEXINGTON

> *"Did not seem to care that I had always been my children's primary caregiver, and my three year old daughter was given to her father with primary custody. When I would address issues she did not seem concerned about my children."*

> *"She did little, never even met children, booked over 5k in fees"*

> *"Ignored evidence"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-stephanie-fajardo/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Amanda Mueller

MEDIATOR · LEXINGTON · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *""The mediation process exposed what I believe is one of the most dangerous realities of family court: temporary emergency allegations can evolve into long-term parental erasure through financial pressure, stigma, and procedural imbalance — even without criminal findings, DSS involvement, or updated judicial review. Instead of functioning as a neutral space for resolution, mediation with Mrs. Mueller felt like pressure to accept permanent restrictions and invasive conditions that would never be tolerated in many other areas of civil or constitutional law.""*

> *"Has had only 1 in person interaction with me which was an initial interview in September of 2024 & no contact since. She maintains VERY consistent contact/communication/interaction with estranged spouse and I get the excessive bill for half. Court won't do a thing about it."*

> *"Worked for CPS prior to atty, also a GAL, Told me my ex's stories are more 'believable' and said "I don't know what to tell you" when I asked her what I should do if I hypothetically had another very real concern about kids safety."*

> *"She did not prepare for my court date and didn't listen to me when I said he would take my son from me. She did not prepare a defense for me at all."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-amanda-mueller/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Christi Zerega CONTINUED 1 / 2

THERAPIST / COUNSELOR · CHARLESTON · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Therapist dropped my case after I shared ex partner emotional abuse event towards my children - I told the therapist prior to this event, abuse would happen to my children when using a technique she wanted me to use - she dropped my case with no referrals and lied about my participation in session. Her notes have inaccurate information reported. She reported false information about financial abuse events I experienced (victim) and presented me as paranoid - though she provided no clinical care or intake, and the services provided were supposed to be only interventions. She violated confidentiality, reported inaccurate clinical labels based on defamation from an abusive ex (she met with too) & lied about my participation - she was unwilling to speak with me after she sent this inaccurate information to 3rd parties, Multiple levels of malpractice and as I was trying to get help for my family she greatly harmed my case through lying, unethical actions based on her license, and she should loose her license. She causes harm to this client & children."* CHARLESTON COUNTY

> *"Can't take notes, passes the buck, zero accountability, seems to have NO ACTUAL PURPOSE other than charging fees for a service set up by a GAL, changes her stories from minute to minute. Keep a careful eye on her and take perfect notes. She is off the chains. HER NAME IS MISPELLED! it is Christi Zerega. She is a liar, useless, can't keep anything together, covers her ass, and puts blame on anyone but herself. She lies, her job to "reunify" is a total joke. She doesn't have any capacity or authority to do anything. Moving goal posts, no clear role, changes story, false reporting to GAL, literally no idea what her purpose is other than to pass the buck"* CHARLESTON, SOUTH CAROLINA

> *"She is a liar. She plays all sides and will tell you exactly what you want to hear and then completely dog you to everyone else. She is a puppet to the GALs and so unethical it's truly unbelievable. My lawyer deposed and she was a huge mess and was caught in lies multiple times. I tell everyone I know to make sure you audio record all of your sessions with her."*

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Christi Zerega CONTINUED 2 / 2

THERAPIST / COUNSELOR · CHARLESTON · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Ignored all safety concerns, did not listen to the children, Ex parte communication with OC, GAL, defendant, prior to her testimony"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-christi-zerega/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Coreen B. Khoury CONTINUED 1 / 2

JUDGE · LANCASTER COUNTY FAMILY COURT SIXTH JUDICIAL CIRCUIT · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Coreen Khoury participates in ex parte communication. She will use your kids as leverage (place them in foster care) to make you comply. She has no understanding or knowledge of domestic violence and therefore should never be allowed to make rulings in such cases. This places children's lives and well being in very serious danger. During the divorce from my ex who was highly abusive she threatened to put my child in foster care if I didn't alter my sworn testimony so it wasn't so damning to my ex. She also separated my two daughters. Gave custody of my oldest to her father because of the domestic violence at my house that was perpetrated by my ex who I hadn't been with in over a year. She allowed me to have joint custody of the youngest daughter that I share with my abuser.After court my ex kidnapped my daughter it took two years to get a court date that she continued and then dismissed after I told her I had not seen my child in 2 years. She gave advice to my ex on how to obtain custody during a child support collection hearing. I wasn't present for . . Signed papers saying I abondaned my child . Signed search warrants for DSS with no real complaint. Has never made my ex pay a dime in child support. Actually suspended his obligation in exparte communication. . After I locate my daughter 4 + years later this judge gives my ex temporary primary custody. He hasn't allowed me a single visit. My daughter finally run away from his home and discloses the abuse with audio evidence she has endured for years so the judge puts her in foster care where she has been since the discoosure . Currently in a group home and they are still allowing visits from her father not to mention I was forced to proceed unrepresented each hearing."*

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Coreen B. Khoury CONTINUED 2 / 2

JUDGE · LANCASTER COUNTY FAMILY COURT SIXTH JUDICIAL CIRCUIT · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Since my ex got a new attorney over a year ago, every time this judge hears our case, no matter how much it is obvious that my ex has not followed orders and is in the wrong, this judge sides with him and his attorney. She has refused for me to have my rule to show cause motion heard for over a year, despite clear evidence that my ex has committed perjury in court and is refusing to follow over ten orders, leaving me and our children in financial ruin with $0 in support from him. She has refused to order child support or alimony in my case. She has continued trial with no documentation that supports the need to do so. She has refused to hear multiple motions of mine asking for reconsideration of temporary orders."*

> *"With no reason whatsoever other than an unfounded dss case, discontinued all of my visitation for a year now. Had a hearing a few months ago, she refused to change anything at all. We were supposed to be pending a GAL investigation. GAL was done with her report before 2025 was over. It was only supposed to be 60 days."* LANCASTER

> *"Used my disability of multiple sclerosis against me after she acquired my medical records illegally and she was the cause of my house burning down because of her negligence Used my medical condition of multiple sclerosis to discriminate against me and alienate me from my son."* CHESTER, FAIRFIELD, LANCASTER

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-coreen-b-khoury/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Elizabeth Stringer

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · CHARLESTON COUNTY · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Did not contact school officials or witnesses, twisted or completely fabricated children's statements, false testimony, did not follow up on safety concerns brought up by the children. Lied under oath multiple times."* BERKELEY

> *"Submitted falsified evidence, helped client hide money, made disparaging remarks to me while I was pro se. Ex parte communication with the judge in the final hearing. Litigation abuse."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-elizabeth-stringer/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Greg Seigler

JUDGE · LEXINGTON · **5 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Judge Seigler gave my ex husband primary custody of young children from exes first and second wife. Both wives were the primary parent during the marriage. Once dad was finished with each marriage he was all of a sudden interested in parenting by filing "Emergency Motions" and stating the mother's were "unfit." Gave my ex husband primary custody of our two daughters who were 3 and 7 when I had always been their primary caregiver. He also gave my ex husband primary custody of his two older daughters when their mother had always been the primary caregiver. I raised his older daughters because my ex husband alienated his older daughters from their mother. Judge Seigler is not trained in Domestic Violence or Coercive Control."*

> *"" scheduling clerk have been advised (by him) can not schedule this motion on his docket till I am instructed by him. I do understand that it is hindering your other motions and rules from being scheduled." Motion was heard-"*

> *"Ignored factual evidence"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-greg-seigler/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Michelle Hurley

JUDGE · RICHLAND · **5 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"She was supposed to rule on a change in school and instead she flipped a switch and made my ex primary on everything regarding decision making (after I was primary for years). She also changed our custody schedule from week to week to me only seeing the kids every other weekend. There was no cause for this, the schedule was not the issue. Gave my ex primary on everything and primary custody after years of me being primary. He had never been to the dentist, orthodontist, doctor appointments, etc, probably couldn't tell you who their doctors are. She saw me as a conservative and she is very liberal. She pushed her ideas onto me and "judged" me for being different than her. The funny part is that my ex is similar in political viewpoints, but his lawyer is slick and had him pretend. The lawyer also insinuated strongly that my husband and I are racist (ridiculous) and she is an African American judge."*

> *"Separated children from mother without due process Put me in my 18 month old out of the house with no financial income, and no place to go. because I left the abusive partner she said a forfeit in my home. And gave the home and three other children primary to dad who had income and family in the state and a business he could stay at."*

> *"Ignored evidence proving false allegations and flipped custody."*

> *"Judged solely on hearsay"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-michelle-hurley/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Mindy W. Zimmerman

JUDGE · HORRY COUNTY, SC · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Entered contempt findings and rulings that suspended my financial support and transferred future medical appointment authority for my children solely to the other parent while I was self-represented in court"*

> *"Was assigned to portions of your case at different times. You have raised concerns about scheduling, notice, and procedural issues during the litigation."*

> *"DENIED ME THE RIGHT TO KNOW WHERE MY CHILDREN WHERE AT FOR CHRISTMAS THEY WERE OUT OF STATE WITH FOSTER CARE"*
> LAURENS

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-mindy-w-zimmerman/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Rochelle Conits

JUDGE · GREENVILLE · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"she allowed my attorney to withdraw just a couple weeks before a highly critical financial hearing that had been continued for months. I had to proceed pro se against the top lawyer in Charleston thanks to this visiting judge's decision, and now have filed an appeal due to another unbelievable ruling. Allowed my attorney to withdraw right before a critical financial hearing, so I was left to appear pro se"*

> *"Violated our due process rights"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-rochelle-conits/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Samer Touma

CUSTODY EVALUATOR · LEXINGTON · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Completely sided with my husband and bullied me relentlessly. It was torturous. He would brag about his kids the whole time. "If I can get along with my ex, I don't see why you can't," was his basic principle. He became very impatient if I would not agree to things on the spot under pressure from him and my ex husband. A horrible person. WAY overpriced!"* RICHLAND

> *"Extremely unqualified. Dr. Touma was unable to detect a severe mental disorder that every other therapist detected immediately. Either that or he was turning a blind eye to obvious facts and evidence that was presented"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-samer-touma/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Meredith Thompson Loftis

THERAPIST / COUNSELOR · GREENVILLE · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Court appointee therapist disregarded all claims of abuse from father. Changed affidavits at last minute asking for over night stays when father didn't even ask for them. So much on her, she is very corrupt and holds protective parents hostage while she runs 1-2 late for appointments. She gave my ex FMLA paperwork when she wasn't his therapist but childs. Fabricates narratives."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-meredith-thompson-loftis/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Monet Stacey Pincus

JUDGE · RICHLAND · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Had no evidence to the accusations my ex claimed against me and believed everything he said."*

> *"Accepted testimony of lies as truth with no evidence, corroborating evidence or proof"*

> *"Gag order biased"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-monet-stacey-pincus/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Nancy T. Jordan

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · LEXINGTON · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Clear bias to father despite clear evidence she ignored and made her opinion known that she favored him and didn't care for mom- not factual just opinion. She spent little time with kids."*

> *"Did not believe children despite forensic interview confirming domestic violence"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-nancy-t-jordan/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Nela Laughridge

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · ANDERSON COUNTY · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-nela-laughridge/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Robert E. Newton

JUDGE · LEXINGTON, SC · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Renoved me from court room per DSS attorneys request, despite knowing I was at emergency hearing and knowing I was there to fight for intervention and placement."* SALUDA

> *"Ex parte communications with opposing counsel and lay GAL"* LEXINGTON

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-robert-e-newton/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Sadia Upright

THERAPIST / COUNSELOR · LEXINGTON, SC · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Kickbacks to attys for referring clients and then provides favorable outcome to highest paying atty."*

> *"Contributed to the negative hearsay"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-sadia-upright/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Wendy M. Bowen

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · LEXINGTON · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"She was listed as an option the attorneys were reviewing, but was clearly following an agenda and aligning with the other attorney we came to learn. She showed extreme bias during first contact and we later found out she had an undisclosed conflict of interest which explained things. Very unethical"*

> *"First meeting told me "those abuse allegations aren't going to hold up in court". Asked me about DV history, wouldn't let me answer. When my son tested pos for marijuana, she advised I "stop pointing fingers at one person". Her L.O.V.E. Lounge Substack/podcast is hysterical."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/sc-wendy-m-bowen/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

SOUTH CAROLINA AT A GLANCE.

Across 123 South Carolina families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED
217
122 of 123 families reported child counts

MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN
$120,500
median across 78 families reporting 3+ categories

MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
19
of parenting time

WENT PRO SE
56.1%
69 of 123 who answered; 55 of 123 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN	COUNTIES REPRESENTED
123	1.8	122 of 123	31

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so South Carolina families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

03 THE COST OF SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	84	$25,000	$124,540	$10,461,350
Lost Wages	68	$30,000	$123,252	$8,381,170
Other Court Fees	48	$3,500	$22,694	$1,089,335
Therapy / Evaluations	65	$5,000	$8,215	$533,976
Reunification Services	35	$1,000	$6,154	$215,400
GAL Fees	75	$8,500	$15,826	$1,186,960
Asset Loss [1]	52	$45,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (78 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	$120,500	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($45,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



04 WHO IS REPORTING · SOUTH CAROLINA

Most families documenting in South Carolina are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	58	48%
Case closed: within last 2 years	23	19%
Not provided	19	16%
Not in court but still affected	11	9%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	6	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only	64	52%
Both Family Court and CPS	53	43%
Unknown	4	3%
CPS Only	2	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years	49	40%
3 – 5 years	24	20%
5 – 10 years	17	14%
6 months – 1 year	14	12%
Less than 6 months	9	7%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only	46	37%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access	24	20%
Full Custody	22	18%
50/50 Joint	16	13%
Children in Foster Care	9	7%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Charleston	17	17%
Richland	15	15%
Greenville	14	14%
Lexington	9	9%
Horry	5	5%
Anderson	4	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	50	41%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	21	17%
High Conflict Divorce	17	14%
Other	15	12%
Other: (Short answer)	6	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — SOUTH CAROLINA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable South Carolina comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *Traumatized the children, destroyed their childhoods and bankrupt me all in the name of greed.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

I'm a Combat Veteran who is being railroaded by the SC Family Court. I have been denied due process, alienated from my children for 767 days & counting as of May 15, 2026 & I have had to spend almost $50K in attorney fees, court costs & GAL fees with nothing to show & seemingly [...]

— SOUTH CAROLINA PARENT · PETER

MORE VOICES FROM SOUTH CAROLINA

It has financially destroyed me and broken me emotionally. The legal abuse alone has broken me into a person I don't recognize.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ripped my heart out and took my grandsons out of our families life, the only famiky they ever known and traumatized my grandsons emotionally and placed them in a dangerous situation despite me asking how they slept at night and why was this happening. Our lives will never be the [...]

— SHEILA

It has completely destroyed me and my children because of dss negligence and federal and civil rights being violated my children had to be hospitalized for suicide and it caused me so much emotional damage I ended up in a coma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my finances and empowered an abuser.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has torn my family to screds an me nor the kids deserved to be ripped from each other!!!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Murdered my daughter and took my grandchilren

— MICHELE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Family Court is nothing but an extortion ring filled with corrupt court actors lining their pockets at the cost of children. Biggest child trafficking agency in the world. Children left traumatized over and over again while stable loving parents loose everything.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

"I have watched a family court system operate with less accountability and fewer protections than criminal court, where stigma, financial inequality, and abuse of power can separate a devoted parent from their children without the level of due process many criminal defendants [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I left an abusive marriage only to be abused by the system. I have been completely devastated that the children have no voice. No one seems to care.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This family court system has shown my son everything I have raised him not to be but because of this corruption throughout our country it's the most devastating money racket that teaches children how to lie, cheat and steal and use the courts to get away with the crimes.

— JAMES

Richland County Court has continued to ignore evidence of neglect and abuse towards the children. Refuses to acknowledge litigation abuse. and if you're the defendant, you might as well forget it you will forever be guilty. There's no due process but haste, dramatic, major [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They destroyed our family. I'm a widow, my boys and I have already lost so much. We didn't deserve this.

— SUSAN

The system has traumatized my family while allowing the abuser to lie, conceal assets, dismantle a business, and still be awarded over $100,000 in attorney's fees.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I rebuilt my life in 4 years from nothing when we left our abuser to 6 figure salary, purchased two homes, children had security, and I was healing and thriving. Alienation claims and a notoriously corrupt attorney have taken it all away to punish us but despite the gift of PTSD [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed my family over false allegations and lies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *The system has taken my children, ripped children from their sister based on false allegations that were used knowing what the "temporary" order would entail, and almost 2 years later nothing has changed.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my life and ruined my child.
— VIRGINIA

Expose how corrupted they are and made and my children experience the worst thing ever!!!!
— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has destroyed me and my babies mentally, and emotionally. Cause finance damage, and causing struggle
— LAWANNA

Tormented my children and myself by enabling our abuser to the point of suicidal ideation in a 9 year old!
— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has attempted to viciously fracture my role as a mother and deteriorate my ability to provide as a newly single parent. Instead of helping us out of an abusive situation- it has acted as a method to harm us futher with institutionalized and legal abuse.
— BRENNA

Allowed my exwife to remove me from my son's life and replace me with her new husband. Years later she still emails my place of work claiming making false claims even after my rights were terminated.
— BRENT

I have literally lost everything became homeless. Lost my special needs child due Domestic Violence and narcissist
— JAYME

On top of not being able to parent my son, after years of him being in our home, my step-children have been traumatized, and my wife has been beyond depressed. The harm inflicted upon my family is immeasurable.
— THOMAS

Allowed financial abuse through litigation. Hoping to get care for my children and experience multiple misconduct events from a therapist & lying in notes and to 3rd parties.
— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Absolute familial and financial destruction. I was the primary parent, and they are with an abuser and have been for 11 month. This is the most corrupt system I have ever seen.
— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *The family court system has singlehandedly destroyed my family. We have been separated for years and only see them a few times a year. It will probably cause my younger kids to go through therapy at some point.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cost me custody of all my kids because she refused to acknowledge the facts and the real evidence!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This has destroyed my family and my finances.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Permanent irreparable damage to my kids- homelessness three times, constant terror, bankruptcy two times, unspeakable horrors and losses. The abuser called all the shots and those of us that tried to advocate for the child- mom, therapist and child themselves- all lost [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has taken my child from me and left me fighting through delays, legal barriers, and financial strain that have drained my savings, my mental health, and my ability to function normally. It has cost me years of time with my children and caused deep emotional harm to [...]

— GRISEL

Kidnapped my kids from their grandmas house. Jennifer McCartha the sister of Austin smith attempted to kill my wife and died himself as well. They kidnapped the kids for false accusations lies. Lied to police and said they had already had an emergency order which they didn't [...]

— DEVEN

Temporary custody proceedings turned my children, medical hardship, and parental rights into a system I could barely recognize. Instead of protecting stability and communication, the process escalated conflict, isolated me from important decisions involving my daughters, and [...]

— LAURA

The Family Court System was used control and abuse me by an abuser that loves to fool legal system to do the abuse for them. They feel more powerful that way and I just learn that there is just more pain if I ask for help.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The impact of my experience with the court system extended far beyond legal proceeding. This altered the course of my family's stability, challenged my sense of security, and required a level of strength I continue to draw on every day.

— DONNA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *They underestimated a mother's strength—no matter what this system has done, I'm still standing, and I'm coming for my son.*
>
> — PAULETTE

Completely restored not only hope in justice but teaching my son that bad behavior and lies gets rewarded

— EDEE

Family court gave my abuser custody of two of my children with no DNA proof of relation. The oldest of the two was not his but the court claimed phycological parent, the younger was never DNA tested even when I asked for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system took my child for two months for no reason, she got ahold of my straightener burnt her leg it healed fine went to 4 pediatric doctors, as well as an abuse doctor at the Julie Valentine Center, they refuse to give me the report from JVC and getting me for physical [...]

— BAILEY

They have torn my daughter from me 2 weeks after n her father died. Took her away from her brother. Broke our bond. Broke my heart. Ruined our lives!

— SHONNA

No proof given was defaulted got annilated

— ANDREW

I remember the screams from my kids on the phone when I told my husband that we needed to get the kids ready to go to their dad's house. For six years I have battled, for a year I haven't seen them, for five months now...my daughter has refused to talk to me.

— HEATHER

The system has caused irreparable harm to my family. My youngest child atill hasn't dealt with the trauma she has experienced. She is terrified to be away from us now. Family court is a child trafficking ring and needs ABOLISHED!

— PETER

It has destroyed the relationship of a child, parent, and entire family. Caused medical issues such as a bipulmonary embolism. Fear of retaliation and inability to fight for or protect a child. I am speaking for my husband as he has been gagged due to my social media.

— NICOLE

78 South Carolina parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 46 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — SOUTH CAROLINA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from South Carolina families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> Traumatized the children, destroyed their childhoods and bankrupt me all in the name of greed.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> It has financially destroyed me and broken me emotionally. The legal abuse alone has broken me into a person I don't recognize.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> Ripped my heart out and took my grandsons out of our families life, the only famiky they ever known and traumatized my grandsons emotionally and placed them in a dangerous situation despite me asking how they slept at night and why was this happening. Our lives will never be the same. Had i not actually lived this, I would never believe a system designed to care for the best interest of the children has turned into what is in the best interest of themselves and then promoted to director the same day temp custody was ordered and they had closed their case all in less than 6 months.
>
> — SHEILA

> I'm a Combat Veteran who is being railroaded by the SC Family Court. I have been denied due process, alienated from my children for 767 days & counting as of May 15, 2026 & I have had to spend almost $50K in attorney fees, court costs & GAL fees with nothing to show & seemingly no end in sight.
>
> — PETER

> It has completely destroyed me and my children because of dss negligence and federal and civil rights being violated my children had to be hospitalized for suicide and it caused me so much emotional damage I ended up in a coma.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> Destroyed my finances and empowered an abuser.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It has torn my family to screds an me nor the kids deserved to be ripped from each other!!!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Murdered my daughter and took my grandchilren

— MICHELE

Family Court is nothing but an extortion ring filled with corrupt court actors lining their pockets at the cost of children. Biggest child trafficking agency in the world. Children left traumatized over and over again while stable loving parents loose everything.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

“I have watched a family court system operate with less accountability and fewer protections than criminal court, where stigma, financial inequality, and abuse of power can separate a devoted parent from their children without the level of due process many criminal defendants receive. False allegations can become permanent without meaningful judicial review, opinions can outweigh facts, and mental health can be weaponized and stigmatized regardless of diagnosis or actual parenting ability. No criminal charges were filed, no DSS findings existed, yet a broken system still had the power to erase me as a parent — stripping away fundamental civil liberties, due process, and years of irreplaceable time between a mother and her children. The greatest long-term damage is not what happened to me, but what happens to children forced to grow up without understanding why a loving parent disappeared from their daily lives, while financial power and control outside the courtroom pressure parents into surrendering their rights simply because they cannot afford to survive the fight.”

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I left an abusive marriage only to be abused by the system. I have been completely devastated that the children have no voice. No one seems to care.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This family court system has shown my son everything I have raised him not to be but because of this corruption throughout our country it’s the most devastating money racket that teaches children how to lie, cheat and steal and use the courts to get away with the crimes.

— JAMES

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Richland County Court has continued to ignore evidence of neglect and abuse towards the children. Refuses to acknowledge litigation abuse. and if you're the defendant, you might as well forget it you will forever be guilty. There's no due process but haste, dramatic, major changes that traumatize parents, and children for years, waiting for resolution. Richland County family Court will push a parent and a poverty just to preserve a court order even if that parent didn't have the ability to pay child support. They now garnish 60% of my check every two weeks and I can no longer even pay my rent and they don't care.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They destroyed our family. I'm a widow, my boys and I have already lost so much. We didn't deserve this.

— SUSAN

The system has traumatized my family while allowing the abuser to lie, conceal assets, dismantle a business, and still be awarded over $100,000 in attorney's fees.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I rebuilt my life in 4 years from nothing when we left our abuser to 6 figure salary, purchased two homes, children had security, and I was healing and thriving. Alienation claims and a notoriously corrupt attorney have taken it all away to punish us but despite the gift of PTSD they expect us to continue to suffer from, we have found our hope in God's love, justice, and mercy. Praise God for His renewal and peace in the midst of our persecutions and suffering!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed my family over false allegations and lies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has taken my children, ripped children from their sister based on false allegations that were used knowing what the "temporary" order would entail, and almost 2 years later nothing has changed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

> Destroyed my life and ruined my child.
>
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> Expose how corrupted they are and made and my children experience the worst thing ever!!!!
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> Tormented my children and myself by enabling our abuser to the point of suicidal ideation in a 9 year old!
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> — BRENNA

> Allowed my exwife to remove me from my son's life and replace me with her new husband. Years later she still emails my place of work claiming making false claims even after my rights were terminated.
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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

On top of not being able to parent my son, after years of him being in our home, my step-children have been traumatized, and my wife has been beyond depressed. The harm inflicted upon my family is immeasurable.

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cost me custody of all my kids because she refused to acknowledge the facts and the real evidence!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This has destroyed my family and my finances.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Permanent irreparable damage to my kids- homelessness three times, constant terror, bankruptcy two times, unspeakable horrors and losses. The abuser called all the shots and those of us that tried to advocate for the child- mom, therapist and child themselves- all lost everything and were discredited. Hold them accountable

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

This system has taken my child from me and left me fighting through delays, legal barriers, and financial strain that have drained my savings, my mental health, and my ability to function normally. It has cost me years of time with my children and caused deep emotional harm to my family, including my daughter losing precious time with her brother.

— GRISEL

Kidnapped my kids from their grandmas house. Jennifer McCartha the sister of Austin smith attempted to kill my wife and died himself as well. They kidnapped the kids for false accusations lies. Lied to police and said they had already had an emergency order which they didn't file until the day after. We are doing our best but it seems like we're losing even after paying 10k for my wife to have a lawyer and I'm having to get a seperate lawyer for some reason I guess because the youngest is my only biological son and he's been kept from me and I haven't been able to see him 1 time. Not a single reason to do so either

— DEVEN

Temporary custody proceedings turned my children, medical hardship, and parental rights into a system I could barely recognize. Instead of protecting stability and communication, the process escalated conflict, isolated me from important decisions involving my daughters, and caused severe emotional and financial harm to our family

— LAURA

The Family Court System was used control and abuse me by an abuser that loves to fool legal system to do the abuse for them. They feel more powerful that way and I just learn that there is just more pain if I ask for help.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— PAULETTE

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— BAILEY

They have torn my daughter from me 2 weeks after n her father died. Took her away from her brother. Broke our bond. Broke my heart. Ruined our lives!

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— ANDREW

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— HEATHER

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— PETER

It has destroyed the relationship of a child, parent, and entire family. Caused medical issues such as a bipulmonary embolism. Fear of retaliation and inability to fight for or protect a child. I am speaking for my husband as he has been gagged due to my social media.

— NICOLE

The Charleston County Family Court system, aligned with a vindictive parent, tore apart our happy family, caused trauma beyond imagination, and made it hard to even get out of bed many mornings.

— KATE

This system has taken my children out of my rightful full custody and handed them to my human traffickers and caused that I have no safe place to birth my 3rd child and might die while giving birth.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Went in as a DV victim and mother who raised her 2 kids only to be subjected to half a million dollars to even see my kids. Removed to father who don't even take of them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused an incredible injustice to my son and I

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I'm a preacher who has never been in trouble with the law. My friends are in shock this is happening and not shocked my wife is asking for $130,000 + $25,000 to pay her attorneys bill and pay her for life alimony. The judge didn't care about my autistic adult son and my ability to find someone to care for him while incarcerated.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has totally ruined my relationship with my daughterd

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has cost me law school as I dropped out because I was unable to focus while fighting for my child. I could not handle the weight of both. I have missed work, lost sleep, been diagnosed with anxiety and the financial burden alone is enough to bury someone. I have had to borrow so much just to keep up with legal fees and had attorneys tell me they would not file an emergency motion if I could not come up with the money to pay for the motion even though they believed my child was in danger.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tore my family apart. My twins will be ok but I never will get back my time.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

HOW CAN i FILE A FEDERAL SUIT? ThEY CAN NOLONGER USE REUSE INFORMATION Part-2 gives us rights to our protected private medical information, but they are still doing it

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Parental alienation is treated as invalid

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Richland Family Court is a chess board of paid players and you are a pawn. They bring in more actors at your expense (for no justified reason), prolonging the game and padding their "friends" pockets. It's sad, abusive, and has damaged my children and me financially and emotionally.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Lexington County Family Court has ruined my opportunity to be a mother to my children. This is why I am a strong supporter of 50/50 parenting time/custody post divorce.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Completely lost my Faith in humanity.. chose to go with the narrative and leave out critical evidence that would have assured the reunification of My Daughter and I. Used me being a single Mother as ammunition. Has caused an unbearable amount of grief and trauma that will never go away for Myself or My Daughter. My state appointed Attorney told me to “Just accept and be happy either way whatever outcome because ‘Atleast She was going to a family member’ .”

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Please see my previous submission.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Why is it ok for strangers to take over your whole family and never help, only hurt, misuse, violate, and abuse, and never own it, never suffer any consequences?

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Malicious fracturing of attachment

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Multiple people in the DSS system repeatedly apologized and said this should never happen. I don't trust DSS leadership, I learned they are a love, hate relationship. We were great for 3 years, and then in the final hearing so many lies. DSS turned on us. In the end our grandaughter has been adopted. We see her all the time.....She asks us all the time why she could not live with us. Greenville SCDSS is evil, they lie and manipulate, they create orders, (not always legal) and then Cherry Pick how the order outcome should be--its not about the child!

— STEPHEN

The family court system has failed myself and my daughter greatly by turning the abuser into the victim an giving him full power over our lives. Ten years in and my daughter's meantal health will be impacted forever.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has taken everything from me, torn my family apart at a cost/debt that will be paid ultimately by my children. Everyone close to me has been affectedband are at a lose.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I reported concerns my child raise of department of social services. Due to multiple reports being unfounded I've lost primary custody. My ex is military and deployed and the judge is leaving my child with the step mom. Despite never being notified and her not having guardianship or custody.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has left us fighting for our peace and safety while being told I need to trust the man who has abused me for years and continues to use the courts to hurt me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We have lost so much time, and now my daughter does not want to see or speak to me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Knowingly Prying on the bereaved., Using my already diagnosed mental health cause More mental anguish mental distress mental harm to my family, soul bound

— ROBIN

This system has illegally interfered in the growth and productivity of my family emotionally, physically, and spiritually. Their tactics are evil and they present themselves as protectors while knowing deep down inside there's nothing honest in their own behavior and activities that bring financial windfalls within their offices.

— DARRYL

The system has taken my oldest son from a large, loving family with over 30+ extended family members including three siblings that miss him dearly, and given him to a mentally sick chronically single woman who lives with her mentally sick chronically single mother. It has robbed us of every penny my wife of 12 years and I had in our retirement, savings, and bank accounts. It continues to pull us back and impose extra fines for inability to pay previous fines. We have three small children and are now forced to give up our home due to financial ruin.

— ARTHUR

The family court system has left my daughter and me trapped in years of conflict, where I believe procedural failures and prolonged litigation have taken precedence over our family's stability, our relationship, and my ability to protect and care for her.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has crushed me and torn me down to pieces. I still have my belongings in the house from 3 yrs ago because my ex is that dangerous. My son is scared for his life living with his father 65% of the time. He has had to lie about things he knows are not true to the sake of his life being in danger. He is forced to be around my abusive father against his will. My son has had 3 unknown causes of injury. My ex keeps needles for illegal drugs on the counter in the bathroom next to my son's toothbrush. My son has missed over 20 days of school majority with his father in the last 3 school years.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

> After attempting to report long term stalking and harassment concerns, non custodial parent came and removed child transporting over state lines back to their home county, found out I was never officially divorced when served with temporary emergency custody order that my attorney failed to object or submit evidence to dispute. Temporary order then became final order after over a year of attorneys dragging out what could have immediately been dismissed
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> Child feels very unheard and that no one is going to help. Key facts and evidence ignored in favour of other party regardless. Can do into more detail if needed
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> The system along with my cousin and drive away so deep between me and my daughter that I don't know that it could ever be fixed and they allowed that to happen
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> Too much to write here.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> Motivated me to expose it. All of it. Husband hid cameras in my house- secretly recording me. Had to hire 5 lawyers. Family, case law, dss, wiretapping, criminal. Women that don’t have several hundred thousand dollars to fall back on never see their kids and go to prison for things they didn’t do in these situations. God has saved us. The system has failed us.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

78 full approved South Carolina comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this South Carolina report comes from South Carolina respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in South Carolina — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 123 South Carolina families reporting here are not the universe of South Carolina families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – October 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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